Just before sunrise, large numbers of Afghans had massed in the darkness to the rear of the British camp. As the sepoys were rising to find yet more frozen corpses littering the ground around the few remaining tents, it was there that the fighting began: ‘The scene at sunrise was fearful,’ wrote Hugh Johnson.

> The Force was perfectly disorganised. Every man appeared to be so paralysed with cold as to be scarcely able to hold his musquet or move a step. Some of the enemy having appeared on the rear of the bivouack, the whole of the camp followers rushed to the front in one huge mass: men, women and children . . . The ground was strewn with boxes of ammunition, and property of various kinds. The enemy soon assembled in great numbers. Had they made a dash among us we could have offered no resistance and every one of us would have been slaughtered.[38]

Instead, the frontmost troops and followers were skilfully herded into the mouth of the Khord Kabul Pass,the women led by Lady Sale – ‘I felt very grateful for a tumbler of sherry which at any other time would have made me feel most unladylike.’ At the same time General Elphinstone’s staff spotted a group of Afghan horsemen standing at some distance to the rear under a banner, clearly directing proceedings. It was correctly assumed that this was Akbar Khan, and Mackenzie and Lawrence were sent off to renegotiate the safe passage they had been promised in Kabul. Akbar Khan agreed that if his friends Mackenzie and Lawrence were again to be surrendered as hostages, he would send his most influential men ahead ‘to clear the pass from the Ghilzais who occupied it’.[39] The terms were accepted.

‘We proceeded’, wrote Lawrence afterwards, ‘escorted by two of Akbar’s dependents, through crowds of the enemy, until we reached the Sirdar. We found [Akbar] seated on the side of a hill at breakfast, which he civilly asked us to partake of, ordering at the same time his men to take away our firearms . . . We then sat down, not without a shudder at eating from the same dish as the man who had been so lately the murderer of the Envoy.’[40] Shortly afterwards, while Akbar gently chided the two young officers for leaving Kabul before he could arrange for their protection, the two heard great fusillades of musketry from within the pass. The advance guard had just been shepherded into a perfectly executed ambush.

For days, so it became clear afterwards, the Ghilzais had been preparing for this moment. Embankments, shallow trenches and rubble sangars had been carefully erected out of the range of the British muskets but